had not misrepresented its content. Kennedy felt vindicated. “It’s going to be hung up there now,” he told the aides. “This is their proposal.” He did not want to hear any objections. “How much negotiations have we had with the Turks this week?” asked Kennedy, cutting short an aide’s remarks. “Who’s done it?” continued the president. “We haven’t talked with the Turks,” responded Rusk, adding: “The Turks have talked with us.” “Where have they talked with us?” Kennedy kept pushing. “In NATO,” responded Rusk. Kennedy was no longer hiding his frustration. “Yeah, but have we gone to the Turkish government before this came out this week? I’ve talked about it now for a week. Have we had any conversations in Turkey, with Turks?”

Rusk tried to defend himself, pointing out that the State Department had asked for the opinions of American ambassadors in Rome and Ankara. Undersecretary of State George Ball explained the rationale: “If we talked to the Turks, I mean that would be extremely unsettling business.” Kennedy wanted none of that. “Well, this is unsettling now, George,” he shot back. He then added, referring to Khrushchev: “[H]e’s got us in a pretty good spot here.” Kennedy had in mind the public relations consequences of Khrushchev’s letter: “Most people would regard this as not an unreasonable proposal.” But the antiswap party would not give up. “But what ‘most people,’ Mr. President?” asked Bundy, jumping back into the discussion. Kennedy ignored the question but explained his thought in more detail: “I think you’re going to have it very difficult to explain why we are going to take hostile military action in Cuba, against these sites … when he is saying: ‘If you’ll get yours out of Turkey, we’ll get ours out of Cuba.’ ”[12]

Bundy’s solution was akin to the one proposed earlier in the discussion by Nitze: ignore Khrushchev’s Turkey proposal. “I do not see why we pick that track when he’s offered us the other track within the last 24 hours,” said Bundy. “But that offer is a new one,” responded Kennedy. Once again, his argument fell on deaf ears. The ranks of the opposition to the president’s proposal were growing by the minute. “And you think the public one is serious, when we have the private one?’ asked Llewellyn Thompson, the former ambassador to Moscow, probing the president’s defenses. Even Ted Sorensen had joined the anti-Kennedy camp. “I think it is clear that